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Thinking Beyond Classrooms

Distance learning is the ideal way to raise the nation's enrolment ratio

Instead of students going to Aristotle, Aristotle has to go to the students. That's the basic philosophy of Open Distance Learning (ODL). Besides removing the traditional constraints of face-to-face, teacher-centric education, ODL strives to make available the best teachers, the best courses and all types of quality learning resources to any number of students anytime anywhere at affordable costs. Is it wishful thinking or a possibility and a reality?

There are all kinds of myths about ODL. Some of them being: ODL cannot ensure quality; you cannot teach all subjects, particularly science and technology courses; and ODL graduates can't

the existing system. The huge dropout rates and hardly 11 per cent participation of the eligible age group in higher education tell us about the effectiveness of a system that refuses to see the plight of thousands of bright students crying for seats in various colleges.

ODL has the answer. The number of Indian universities (800, including the deemed to be universities), 20,000 colleges and centres of excellence should be seen in relation to demand and supply in a country with a 1.2 billion population. Do we know that to become a developed country, the minimum level of participation in higher education is 40 per cent. Can we reach the benchmark without using ODL?

The total enrolment of distance learners at the higher education level is 3.5 million, which is about 25 per cent of the enrolment at this level. The 11th Plan target is to hike it to 40 per cent. The National Knowledge Commission's recommendation to set up 1,500 new universities can't be implemented in the near future, given the way the 16 new central universities have come up and the controversies over the appointments of their vice-chancellors. Setting up more ODL institutions is imperative to meet the planned targets. The following are the four indispensable requirements to meet the challenges:

- ▶ Create a relevant, flexible, innovative curriculum and formulate quality study material.
- ▶ Ensure efficient student support services.
- ▶ Make sure there is a responsive and effectively managed educational administration.
- ▶ Encourage high quality systemic research and development in all departments.

Without having all the above four, it is impossible to practise genuine ODL. Once it is in place, many of the prejudices about genuine ODL will disappear, as has happened in the developed world. The sheer pressure of numbers, relevance, flexibility and costs will persuade both sceptics and policy makers to take this method of education seriously. We should not throw away the baby along with the bathwater, and the tub. ■

1,500

is the number of universities India needs nationwide to attain a gross enrolment ratio of at least 15 per cent by 2015.

MONEY SHARMA



TEACHING AND LEARNING NO LONGER REQUIRE FACE-TO-FACE INTERACTION

be employed because they are inferior to "regular" students. But these myths can be exploded, if we try to understand ODL's potential and promise. Everyone knows that no country can progress without good education. However, quality education for all, democratisation of education and education at affordable costs have always remained mere dreams for Indians.

Notwithstanding the various commissions and the reports on education, the question of access to quality education for all still remains. If we compare the quality of our classroom courses and millions of unemployed educated youth, and the 5 per cent certified skilled work force, we can well understand the "quality" of